His Daddy

By Cori Thomas

CHARACTERS: *JOHN -- thirties to forties. Caucasian. Works in construction.*
DAVID -- thirties to forties. Must be played by a person of color: African American, Latino, Asian etc. He is an attorney.

PLACE: *The hallway of an institutional building - The morgue.*

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Innocent faces smiling from milk boxes have served as a chilling reminder that childhood is not always safe in America.*
ACTOR 2: *Not all of those missing children are found, and regrettably, some of the cases end in tragedy.*
ACTOR 1: *In this selection, John and David, spent years planning for the surrogate birth of their son Billy*
ACTOR 2: *5 years later, the most horrific parental nightmare occurs.*
TOGETHER: *His Daddy by Cori Thomas*

JOHN: Oh God! Shit! Shit! *(hallway of an institutional building. It is the morgue. John sits on the floor, his hands covering his face. David, dressed in a suit and perhaps tie, emerges from a door.)*

DAVID: You all right?

JOHN: No. Oh God. How could you be so calm in there? It felt like . . . it felt like . . .

DAVID: You got sucker punched.

JOHN: Yeah. Yeah, that's what it feels like.

DAVID: I can't even process . . . I've dreamt about that moment. I practiced

JOHN: You practiced?

DAVID: You know what I mean.

JOHN: No. I don't. I didn't practice anything. I was hoping. I was wishing. I was praying. I was praying.

DAVID: Me too. But, I knew . . . Deep down I knew . . .

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JOHN: Don't say that.

DAVID: I can't help what I felt. *(Beat.)* I was praying too.

JOHN: You just don't know, not until you see . . . and touch . . . *(Exhales.)* you don't know anything . . .

DAVID: I know.

JOHN: *(With deliberate and sudden ferocity.)* You. Don't. You cannot in a thousand years know what it feels like to be me at this particular moment. To have gotten that call and have to come here and identify our son's body.

DAVID: I do. I got that call too.

JOHN: No, David, you don't.

DAVID: OK, I don't. *(Beat.)* Shit! *(Beat.)* Sorry.

JOHN: Yeah right. Sure. Sure.

DAVID: And now we know. OK. We know and it's over.

JOHN: Yes.

DAVID: *(Beat.)* I didn't think that you had . . . I mean, yes I blamed you. I blamed you and I thought you were responsible. I know it makes no sense but you can't help what you feel. I look at you and even now . . . knowing . . . even now . . . *(Dialogue overlaps.)*

JOHN: God, David. This again? Damn it! Damn!

DAVID: I'm sorry. I can't . . . I can't help it.

JOHN: But still . . . ? Really? Still?

DAVID: Going in there and seeing . . . I know that you couldn't . . .

JOHN: *(Making move as if to hit him.)* Don't even go there. Don't you even . . . if for one second that ever crossed your mind . . . You heard what Officer whatever his name in there just said; he waited, that f***head waited patiently till the moment when I let go of Billy's hand. I looked at him like this, *(Shows him.)* So he would know not to move. I took my hand from his to stick in my pocket to get

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the 3 pennies to make the exact buck fifty-eight for the Snickers bar. It was in that moment. That second, and if you know how many times I have gone over this, it was no more than 63 seconds. One minute and 3 seconds. That's the long count. I turned away from Billy for barely more than a minute to put the money on the counter. It was then that I turned my head to look down for him, and noticed he was not there. He wasn't there so I looked around. It took maybe 3 or 4 seconds to begin to feel worried and to start asking the people standing on the line behind me waiting to pay if they had seen a little boy. Some of them looked around too. They shook their head. Not more than 5 seconds and I realized, Oh my God! They think he looks like me. I yelled. "I am looking for a five-year-old boy, he is bi-racial, he does NOT look like me." I don't have to tell you . . . I've told you so many times. You know.

DAVID: Yes. I know.

JOHN: I live it over and over again. In the past six weeks since he disappeared, maybe eight hundred or nine hundred times. I can't stay in here. I gotta get out of here. I'll call you about picking up the rest of my stuff.

DAVID: When do you want to have the funeral?

JOHN: Never. I don't ever want to finalize this

DAVID: We have to.

JOHN: Why?

DAVID: Dr. Pearlman . . .

JOHN: *(Incredulous.)* The therapist!!??

DAVID: I think it helps me.

JOHN: Well, good for you.

DAVID: I'm not like you. You have your work to . . .

JOHN: What? What!

DAVID: Relax! I'm just saying you work with your hands. It's physical . . . construction . .

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It's like going to the gym. Or I don't know . . . yelling.

JOHN: OK, I see what you mean

DAVID: You didn't have to . . . you can . . . not speak to anyone if you don't want to. I have to speak to people all day. On the phone. "How are you?" "How are you?" If you say "Fine." They're like, "Really?" In the halls. In the elevator.

JOHN: I know.

DAVID: You don't! Jerry Johnson calls me in. He's sitting at his desk. He doesn't even get up. He looks at me and I can see in his eyes, I'm just a *(Beat)* you know. Maybe I'm reading into it, I've become so paranoid. Anyway, he doesn't even ask me to sit. I mean I'm a partner, he doesn't even say "David, please sit down." No. He says "I feel for you, but people take one look at you and they know something is wrong. We can't have that in our halls you know. Company morale. I say "I'll work on my demeanor, Sir." He says "Good, you should be over this by now anyway." And I want to say "Don't you tell me what to be feeling. You don't know what I feel. You don't know what I go through every morning to get to this stupid office. How I stand and wait for the bus. You know how that was our thing? I'd drop him off at school and then get back on and go . . . Now, every morning, I see all the people, all the mothers all the kids every one we used to see. They look up and their eyes touch me, and they look down expecting to see Billy, and of course he's not there. Six weeks and they still forget every morning. But then I forget every morning that I'm going to see them too. I wouldn't even get on the bus if I remembered. I feel their pity reaching out to try to curl around me like a boa constrictor and squeeze me but I smile back when instead I feel like snarling and baring my teeth and attacking them for still having their children. These are people who mean me no harm. I know they loved Billy and they care about me but I hate them. *(Beat.)* I can't believe we're here. I can't believe what we saw in there just now *(Beat.)* His body . . .

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cigarette burns . . .

JOHN: That f*****! That f***** asshole!

DAVID: And you were the last person to see him. And I am furious that I let you take him shopping.

JOHN: Wait a minute, you LET me take him shopping?! He was my son. You didn't have to let me take him anywhere.

DAVID: He was my son and you could tell.

JOHN: What are you like two!??? *(Beat.)* It's terrible what I feel in my heart right now, David. And to know that you feel this . . . still? *(Dialogue overlaps.)*

DAVID: I can't help . . .

JOHN: 'Cause he didn't just kill Billy. He killed everything. He killed us. *(Long beat encompasses the "us")* I wanna kill Robert Pierce. I want to hurt him like he hurt Billy. Worse. I want to keep him alive long enough so he'll suffer. Every time he looks like he's going to succumb, I'll back off. Let him come down a little. Let him feel hope that I'll stop, let him catch a breath and that's when I'll come back twice as hard. I'll burn him once the first time, I'll burn him three times the second time. Then I'll start on his knuckles. I'll go at 'em, one at a time with my drywall hammer. I want to hurt him worse than he hurt my little boy. Every single thing he did to Billy, I'm gonna do three or four more times back to him.

DAVID: God, John.

JOHN: This is what I'm thinking David, once the trial begins we figure out when they're moving him, how they're moving him. You got connections with the courthouse . . . so we get him for what he did to our little boy. *(Long beat.)*

DAVID: You would do that?

JOHN: *(Beat.)* Yeah. I think so. *(Beat.)* I think I could.

DAVID: I feel numb. I just feel . . . numb. *(Beat.)* I don't believe you would. You're not

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that kind of person. *(Long beat.)*

JOHN: Not before, but now I know what it feels like . . .

DAVID: I know, but still . . .

JOHN: *(Long beat.)* Yeah. But I mean you know . . . I don't think . . . I really could . . . No.

DAVID: No.

CHILD'S VOICE: Daddy! *(David and John simultaneously turn towards the door.)*

TOGETHER: Billy! *(They both laugh: shocked, embarrassed, overwhelmed.)*

JOHN: I guess . . . some kid . . . Oh my God!

DAVID: Oh my God!

JOHN: Every time I hear that . . . word . . .

DAVID: Yes. *(Long beat.)*

JOHN: We didn't even know if he'd be mine or yours . . .

DAVID: I know

JOHN: He was perfect though, right? He was perfect. He looked like you spit him out. Every time I saw the two of you walking down the street together. It took my breath away. It took my breath away

DAVID: Whenever he got upset, he wanted you - his Daddy John. *(David turns towards John. John turns away from him and looks towards the door.)*

JOHN: OK . . . *(Long beat; John goes to the doorway.)* It's almost like you can feel him.

DAVID: Yes. *(Beat.)* I don't want to leave him in there.

JOHN: I don't even want him to be in there.

DAVID: I know. *(After a long beat, David makes a physical gesture towards John. Something simple and non-sexual but with ramifications of the possibility of something beyond this moment. Lights slowly fade to black.)*

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4N6 Fanatics

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AWARD HISTORY

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